VOL 4: STORY-FILLED RECREATIONS

THE FOULANE FAMILY



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THE FOULANE FAMILY

Vol 4. Playground adventures

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Vol.4

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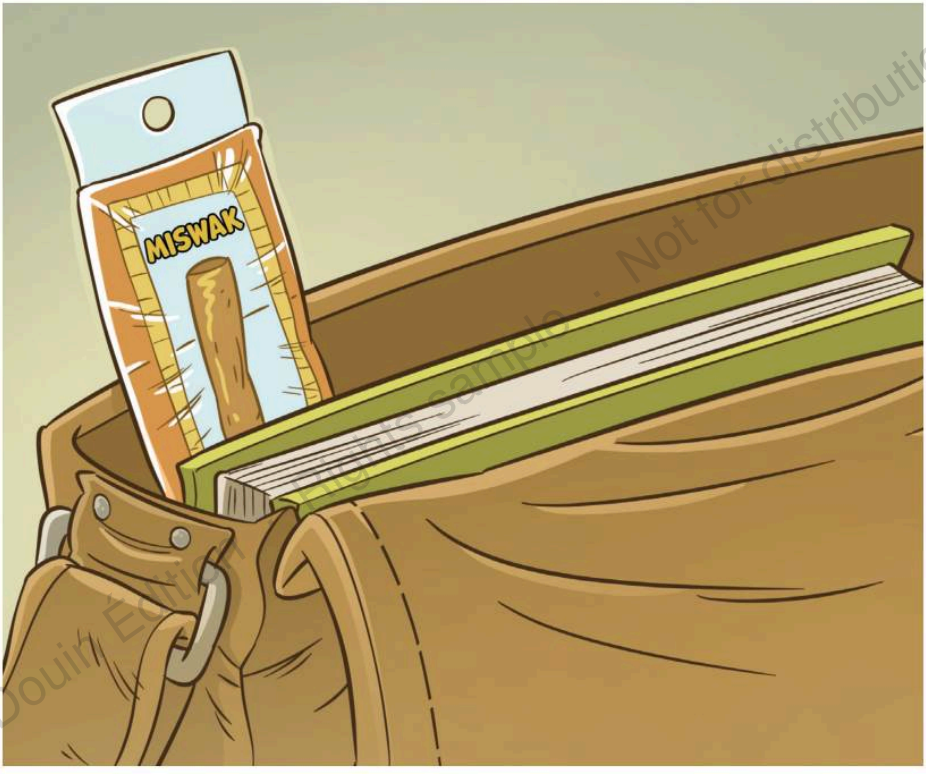
1. Asian miswak

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Sometime ago, Abi gave me my first miswak. What's a miswak? It's a special tree root that we cut into small pieces and use to clean our teeth.

Abi brings them from his shop. There are different sizes and brands available. Some are even wrapped in small clear plastic packets. It's super convenient to carry them around.



But Oummi, she says it's not very eco-friendly:

"Back in the old days, we didn't need this packaging! Just imagine if all the Muslims in the world put their miswak in a little piece of plastic! It would create billions of plastic bags thrown away every month! That would be a huge waste and unnecessary pollution for the planet!"

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The first time my friends saw me with a miswak in my mouth, they didn't understand:

"Is it a piece of licorice?" Rachid asked.



"Mmnooo," I replied while keeping the stick in my mouth.

"Is it a rustic lollipop?" Jeremy asked.

"What?!" Rachid continued.

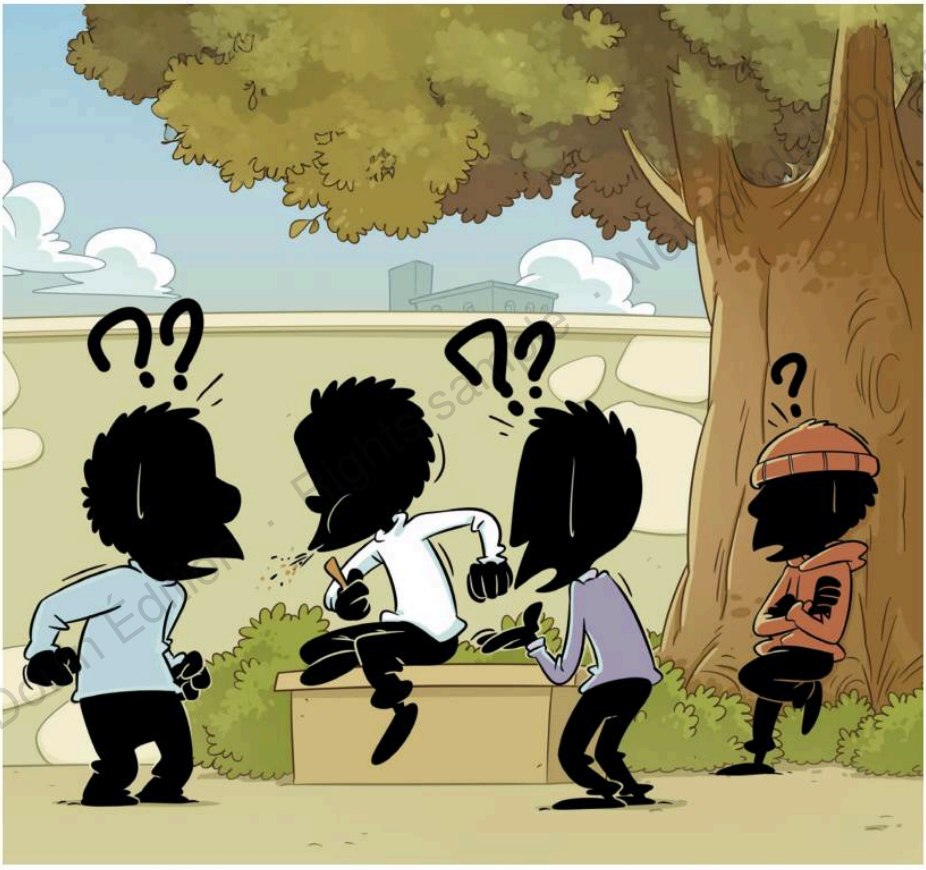
"A rustic lollipop, from the olden days!" he insisted, as if it was obvious. "My mum says that right now, the trend is to do things like they used to be done. For example, a rustic game is a game made only from wood because, back then, plastic didn't exist..."

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“But where do you put the batteries in a wooden game?” Rachid asked.

“Well, that’s the point, you don’t need any!” replied Jeremy. “Because back then, there were no batteries!”

While they were talking about rustic stuff, I spat out some small pieces of bark on the ground.



All my friends looked at me, surprised by my action.

“Whoa! What are you doing?” asked Rachid.

“I’m spitting out some little bits of wood,” I said, while chewing on my miswak.

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“WALAD! Take that piece of wood out of your mouth! We can’t understand a word you’re saying!” exclaimed Anass, who had just joined us.

“I’m SPIT-TI-NG out little bits of wood!” I replied, removing my miswak.

“But why are you doing that?” asked Jeremy.

“Because you don’t eat it! Ha ha!”

As I saw they were all getting a bit frustrated and confused about what I was doing, I decided to end the mystery and explain to them:

“This, dear friends, is a MIS-WAK!”

“And what is it for?” Jeremy inquired.

“Is it edible?” Rachid asked.

“No, no,” I replied. “Actually, it’s a piece of a very special tree root that cleans teeth better than toothpaste.”



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“A toothpaste tree?” Jeremy exclaimed. “You’re not making fun of us, are you?!”

“No, no,” I insisted. “It’s a tree that is well known among Arabs. Back in the time of the Prophet of Islam, peace and blessings be upon him, he used it to clean his teeth. My father told me that many people used it before because toothbrushes didn’t exist back then.”

“Oh! So, it *is* a rustic toothbrush!” Jeremy chimed in, feeling proud to have understood. “It’s an old-fashioned thing!”



“Yes, kind of...”

“But why are you spitting it out?” Anass wondered.

“After some time, the tip of the miswak gets worn out, so you have to nibble on it a bit and throw away the small pieces of bark that protect it. Look, this is what we use to brush our teeth.”

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“Can you lend it to me, just to try?” Rachid asked.

“Well, no! It’s not something you lend! Do you lend your toothbrush to others?” I replied.

“Don’t you have one to give me then?” he insisted.

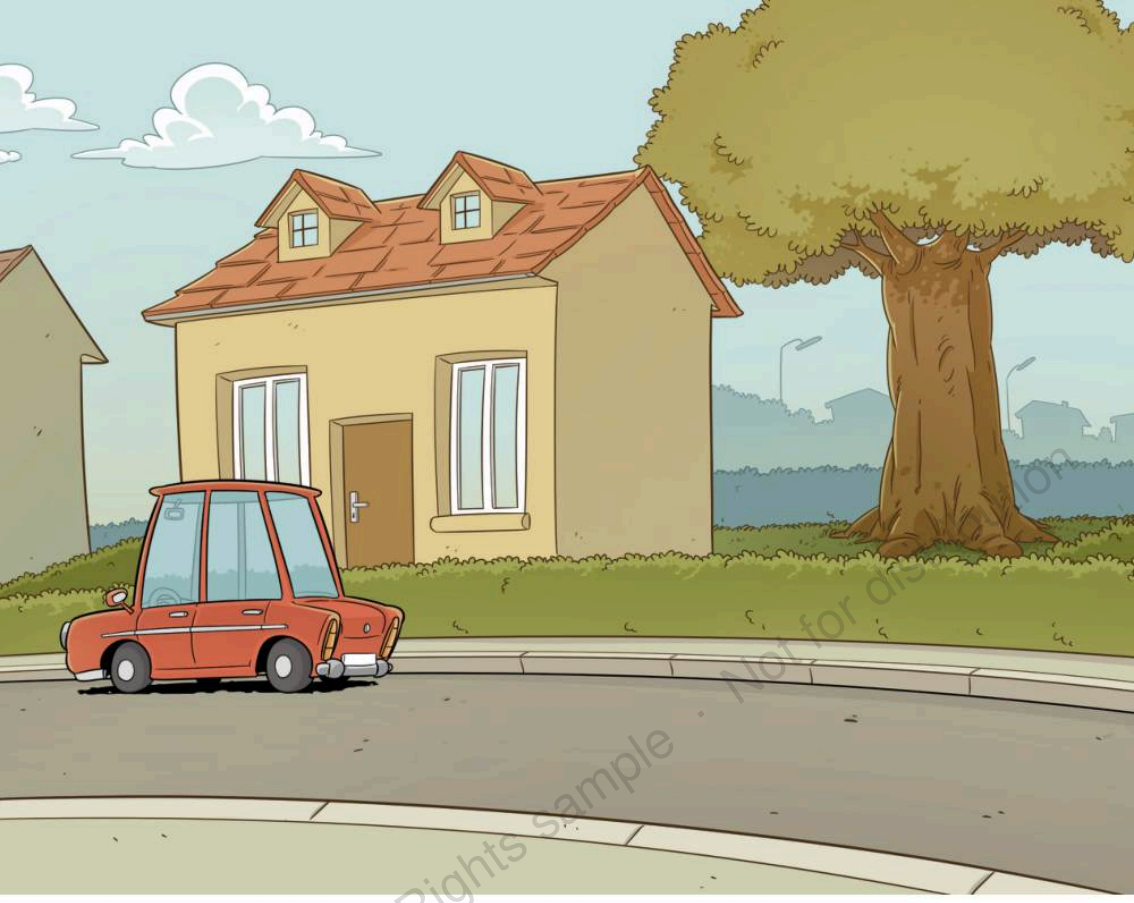
“Nah... But I’ll bring you one tomorrow insha’Allah. I have plenty at home!” I assured.

“For me too?!” Jeremy and Anass added together.

“Alright! No problem! Tomorrow insha’Allah, miswak for everyone! Ha ha!”

The problem is, once I got home, I quickly realised I didn’t have any left.

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I asked Abi if he could give me some miswak for my friends at school, but...

"Sorry, Walad, I'm out of stock!" said Abi. "It's selling so well right now that it's become hard to find in town. If I were dishonest, I could have cut some branches from the tree in the garden and sold them without anyone knowing, ha ha! But, Al hamdoulilah, it's not right to deceive customers."

Oh no, I was hoping to make a good impression on my friends, but it didn't work out! Plus, I had boasted about having plenty at home! They would accuse me of being a liar...

I shouldn't have been so quick to answer them...

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The next day, on the way to school, Binti noticed that I was a bit upset.

"Well, what's wrong, little brother?" she asked.



"There is something wrong..." I replied.

"What's up?"

"I promised my friends that I would give each of them a miswak today, but there are none left at home. Abi said there's none available in the entire city! I'm going to be so embarrassed..."

"Hmmm... Have they ever tasted a real miswak before?"

"Well, no. Why do you ask?" I replied.

"I have an idea!" Binti said, heading towards the park next to the school, which was protected by a small fence.

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She looked left and right, then she quickly jumped over the hedge.

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She walked while crouching to avoid being seen, then she approached an isolated bush.



She then broke a branch with her teeth and removed the small twigs and leaves with her hands.



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She then quickly returned to the pavement.

"But... what are you doing?"



"I'm making miswaks for you! Ha ha!" she said, taking a ruler from her backpack and sawing the branch she had just collected.



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“Oh, but no!” I protested. “Abi said it’s ‘dishonest’ to make miswaks ourselves for others!”

“Dishonest? What does that mean?” she asked.

“I don’t know... but it didn’t sound right.”

“Okay, listen!” she insisted, cleaning the ends of the branch she had just cut. “First of all, these are not for customers, but for friends. Secondly, you’re not going to sell them, you’re going to give them away. And finally, it can’t harm them since they’re just pieces of branches. It’s EXACTLY like miswak.”

She then handed me the pieces of branch, and I must admit, they looked exactly like real miswaks!



“Okay... You’re right... It can’t harm them... And besides, they’re not customers!”

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